CEHD
COLLEGE OF EDUCATION + HUMAN DEVELOPMENT
UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

The Cultural and Professional Impact of Study Abroad Teacher Development Programs: Insights from South Korean Teacher Candidates

Marina Aleixo and Christopher Johnstone

Introduction

Abstract:

The study reports on the experiences of 47 South Korean teacher candidates participating in a study abroad teacher development program. Participants spent one month in the U.S. engaged in teaching experiences in U.S. elementary schools. Although there is a growing trend to provide teachers with global experiences (Marx & Moss, 2011; Cwick & Benton, 2009), few studies examine the experiences of teacher candidates participating in international training programs (Willard-Holt, 2001). Drawing on concepts of situated meaning (Gee, 2002), this study examines the cultural and professional impact of these program on participants' understanding of teaching and learning. Findings suggest that international teaching experiences can be transformative, and deeply impact candidate's perceptions of their roles as educators.

Benefits of International Experiences for Teachers:

- International placements allow new teachers to recognize the importance of culture, its connection to the community and the relationships among language, culture and practice (Roose 2001).

- New teachers who participated in study-abroad programs demonstrate a broader understanding of their classroom role by demonstrating a heightened ability to interact with and teach diverse students (Mahon and Cusher, 2002).

Program Information:

Global Teacher Education Program (GTEP) is a 4 week intensive training program that allows participants to become familiar with the U.S. educational context. GTEP provides visiting educators the opportunity to learn about innovative teaching strategies by attend 2 weeks of lectures and workshops, and then participating in a 2 week teaching practicum in private and public schools. It also exposes visitors to contemporary U.S. culture.

Guiding Research Question:

How does participation in a study abroad teacher development program impact participants' understanding of teaching and learning?

Data



Data Sources:

- 47 South Korean Teacher Candidates
- Program evaluations
- Pre and Post Program Questionnaires
- Classroom Observations
- Teacher Candidate reflections and illustrations
- Debriefing session notes

Data Samples:

Participating in this program impacted my ideas about teaching.
60% Strongly Agree
40% Agree

Participating in this program deepened my cultural awareness of the U.S.
56% Strongly Agree
45% Agree

"Teaching = Interaction between teachers – students"

"I became to think that relationship between teacher and students is important in teaching. It shouldn't be too authoritative and too free."

"I strongly felt that teaching is not just letting kids to know something but also carefully listening to what they are talking and encouraging them to speak out their thinking."

"I will give them [students] various activities and materials. And make them take part in the class"

"I select the strength of US education and Korean education and I will apply them to my education"

Findings and Discussion

Study abroad has often been cited for its academic and cultural benefits, but findings from this study suggest an additional benefit when programs also focus on professional development and skill training. In the case of South Korean teacher candidates, experience in U.S. classrooms sets up a complimentary skill set to existing South Korean teacher preparation programs and classroom environment.

Professional Identity– in classroom experiences allowed participants the opportunity to compare two different professional realities. Reflecting on these experiences resulted in a reimaged teacher role that combined characteristics from both the U.S. and South Korean educational systems.

Developing Professional Skills – the unique design of this program allowed participants the opportunity to be introduced to innovate teaching strategies and then put them into practice by teaching during their practicum placements. As a result participants were able to image ways in which they could implement these new strategies in their own teaching upon return to South Korea.

Conclusion

Findings suggest international teaching experiences can be transformative, and deeply impact candidate's perceptions of their roles as educators, and their understanding of in classroom teaching and learning.

